University of St.Gallen

Course and Examination Fact Sheet: Autumn Semester 2025

7,023: Tech Investing

ECTS credits: 3

Overview examination/s

(binding regulations see below)
decentral - Written work, Digital, Individual work individual grade (20%)
Examination time: Term time
decentral - Presentation, Analog, Group work group grade (80%)
Examination time: Term time

Attached courses

Timetable -- Language -- Lecturer
7,023,1.00 Tech Investing -- English -- Ilic Alexander , Grichnik Dietmar

Course information

Course prerequisites

This course is assigned to the "Start-up & Scale-up Entrepreneurship" profile, but can also be taken without selecting a specialisation.

Learning objectives

After attending this course, students will be able to:

- Explain the differences between VC and founder thinking
- Evaluate if a start-up is suited for venture capital (“VC readiness”)
- Evaluate founder friendliness of term sheets
- Determine funding needs & strategy for a start-up from research to first round
- Write and evaluate an investment memo
- Apply the Scale-Up Navigator due diligence to assess start-up strategy

Course content

Abstract: Venture Capital is important to fund big transformational ideas and is often misunderstood by tech or research entrepreneurs. This lecture immerses participants from both HSG and ETH Zurich in the role of a Venture Capitalist (VC) to learn from experienced entrepreneurs and investors. In small interactive teams, you work on a case of a real start-up and defend the case in a simulated investment committee consisting of experienced VCs.

The seminar is jointly conducted with the ETH Zurich AI Center, featuring guest speakers from leading venture capital firms and start-ups. The course embraces a unique perspective combining technology and investor thinking. The learning experience is hands-on and interactive thanks to a simulated investment committee case. Participants form interdisciplinary teams consisting of both HSG and ETH Zurich students, get pitched by actual Swiss seed start-ups, create a deal memo and defend the case in front of a jury consisting of leading European VCs and investors. The seminar is structured in five days with the following themes:

The macro picture. Why does venture capital exist? What are major tech break-through areas and their disruptive potential? We also review the differences in the US and European perspective as well as developments towards more impact and diversity conscious funds.

A peek into the mind of a VC. How to build a successful VC? Learn what key factors & processes required to build a successful venture capital company. This includes strategic decisions for investment thesis, structure of a fund, portfolio economics, valuation & ownership targets, cap table. In addition, we introduce the fundamentals of the investment process (including due diligence, term sheets, and deal memo) as well as portfolio management.

The founder's perspective. Why should you raise venture capital and how? Learn to evaluate the founder friendliness of terms, company approach, strategic decisions, negotiation and valuation.

Fundraising types. Learn about different types of funding and their implications. This includes an overview of the Swiss ecosystem and a discussion of the different types (grants, equity, loans, SAFE, crowd, …). We also include a practical session on crypto technology for modern fund-raising using launchpads and tokenized shares.

Tying it all together. The last day is focused on simulating an investment committee meeting where the groups present their deal memos and discuss with the audience.

The detailed program is listed here: Link

Course structure and indications of the learning and teaching design

Type: Block seminar (5 days), jointly conducted with the ETH Zurich.

This course counts 3 credits. Accordingly, the total workload for students is 90 hours. This includes self-study, campus time and all examinations. The structure of the contact study is planned as follows: 30 hours of lectures and case studies structured in five days. The structure of the self-study is intended as follows: 20 hours of preparation time for the lectures and 40 hours for the final presentation and reflection paper. The course is conducted in presence partially in St. Gallen and at the ETH Zurich AI Center.

Course literature

Recommended literature: Grichnik, D., Hess, M., Greger, M., Goeldi, A., & Schweitzer, F. (2024). Scale-up Navigator: Das Handbuch für nachhaltigskalierende Start-ups–Vom Start-up zum Outlier. Teil I.

Relevant case studies to be provided during the seminar.

Additional course information

Main instructors of this course are PD Dr. Alexander Ilic (Executive Director, ETH AI Center) and Prof. Dr. Dietmar Grichnik (VP Innovation & Quality, Full Professor of Entrepreneurship and Technology Management).

Alex is a Swiss-German deep tech entrepreneur, researcher, and investor. Alex was a professor at University of St.Gallen (HSG), an e-Lab fellow at MIT, has two exits under his belt as entrepreneur (Dacuda, acquired by Magic Leap 2017) and investor (VAYacquired by Nautilus 2021), was named twice "Entrepreneur of the Year" (2011 by HSG, 2012 by EY) and won the SwissEconomic Award. He is passionate about helping talents to find their path to entrepreneurship as chairman of Talent Kick andboard member of the student-run S2S Ventures.

Dietmar is a leading professor in entrepreneurship, innovation and finance. He is Director of the Institute of Technology Management at the University of St. Gallen, where he also holds the Chair of Entrepreneurship. He was recently elected to the President's Board of the University of St. Gallen as Vice President for Innovation & Quality. His research has been published in leading journals and he is co-author of the "St. Gallen Navigator Trilogy" for Startups, Scale-ups and Corporate Venturing. As a business angel and limited partner of venture capital firms, Dietmar is actively involved in supporting technology entrepreneurs in the US and Europe.

Teaching assistant contact: Noah Lauffer (noah.lauffer@unisg.ch).

Examination information

Examination sub part/s

1. Examination sub part (1/2)

Examination modalities

Examination type	Written work
Responsible for organisation	decentral
Examination form	Written work
Examination mode	Digital
Time of examination	Term time
Examination execution	Asynchronous
Examination location	Off Campus
Grading type	Individual work individual grade
Weighting	20%
Duration	--

Examination languages

Question language: English
Answer language: English

Remark

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Examination-aid rule

Free aids provision

Basically, students are free to choose aids. Any restrictions are defined by the faculty members in charge of the examination under supplementary aids.

Supplementary aids

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2. Examination sub part (2/2)

Examination modalities

Examination type	Presentation
Responsible for organisation	decentral
Examination form	Oral examination
Examination mode	Analog
Time of examination	Term time
Examination execution	Asynchronous
Examination location	On Campus
Grading type	Group work group grade
Weighting	80%
Duration	--

Examination languages

Question language: English
Answer language: English

Remark

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Examination-aid rule

Free aids provision

Basically, students are free to choose aids. Any restrictions are defined by the faculty members in charge of the examination under supplementary aids.

Supplementary aids
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Examination content

Presentation (15 mins + Q&A) & group work: analysis, creation & presentation of a deal memo for an assigned startup case.

Individual paper (3 pages) that delves into the Scale-up Navigator due diligence, requiring students to critically assess the assigned startup's strategy and propose actionable improvement measures.

Examination relevant literature

Relevant case studies to be provided during the seminar.

Please note

Please note that only this fact sheet and the examination schedule published at the time of bidding are binding and takes precedence over other information, such as information on StudyNet (Canvas), on lecturers' websites and information in lectures etc.
Any references and links to third-party content within the fact sheet are only of a supplementary, informative nature and lie outside the area of responsibility of the University of St.Gallen.

Documents and materials are only relevant for central examinations if they are available by the end of the lecture period (CW51) at the latest. In the case of centrally organised mid-term examinations, the documents and materials up to CW 43 (Freitag, 24. October 2025) are relevant for testing.

Binding nature of the fact sheets:

- Course information as well as examination date (organised centrally/decentrally) and form of examination: from bidding start in CW 34 (Thursday, 21 August 2025);
- Examination information (supplementary aids, examination contents, examination literature) for decentralised examinations: in CW 42 (Monday, 13. October 2025);
- Examination information (supplementary aids, examination contents, examination literature) for centrally organised mid-term examinations: in CW 43 (Freitag, 24. October 2025);
- Examination information (regulations on aids, examination contents, examination literature) for centrally organised examinations: two weeks before ending with de-registration period in CW 45 (Monday, 03. November 2025).